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PepsiCo to Integrate North American Snacks and Beverages Units

PepsiCo will integrate its North American snacks and beverages businesses under a new "One North America" strategy to improve productivity and competitiveness. CEO Ramon Laguarta announced the move during the Q2 2025 earnings call, saying it would "modernise our company and improve our agility." The integration will involve Frito-Lay North America ($24.8B revenue in 2024) and PepsiCo Beverages North America ($27.8B), with Quaker Foods North America ($2.7B) possibly included. Laguarta said the plan aims to streamline value chain tasks and cut costs over the next 3–4 years. CFO Jamie Caulfield added that PepsiCo expects 70% more productivity savings in H2 2025, especially at Frito-Lay. PepsiCo also plans a major protein beverage launch, focusing on natural, great-tasting products. The company's international

arm, which generated 40% of its $91.8B revenue in 2024, remains a key growth driver. Details on the structural integration are yet to be disclosed.

DormFresh and TASC Open High-Tech Potato Storage Research Center in Germany

DormFresh Ltd. and TASC International (Germany) GmbH have opened a €600,000 Trial and Research Center in Rosche, Lower Saxony, focused on sustainable alternatives to chemical sprout inhibitors. The 310 m^2 facility features six gas-tight storage chambers with automated climate control for simulating precise conditions across 36 tons of storage. The center responds to the EU's ban on chlorpropham (CIPC), supporting regulatory trials under GEP and ISO standards. "This joint facility allows us to align product innovation with the practical needs of our storage and trading partners," said Lars Willem Köpp, Managing Director of TASC. DormFresh, known for its 1,4SIGHT® product, brings expertise in sustainable post-harvest solutions. The partnership aims to enhance supply chain integration, regulatory compliance, and storage quality. Initial trials are underway, with the center expected to set new industry benchmarks in sprout control and sustainable storage practices.

European Frozen Fry Exports Rebound, But Price Pressures Persist

EU 5 frozen fry exports reached 516,121 tonnes in April, up 1.2% from March, marking a second month of modest recovery. However, cumulative exports for January–April remain well below previous years, with Belgium and the Netherlands hit hardest. Dutch volumes rose 5% in April, while Belgian exports posted a slight gain. Despite this, pricing remains under pressure. Belgium recorded the lowest average price at €1,180/tonne (~$1,326), while the Netherlands and France held higher averages at €1,370 and €1,538, respectively. Dutch processors' reliance on fixed contracts helped shield them from spot market volatility, unlike Belgian suppliers. Global demand remains weak: UK imports fell 10.6%, Spain 28%, the U.S. 9%, and Saudi Arabia 41%. The shift in Saudi procurement towards Asia highlights changing trade patterns. While recent gains hint at stabilisation, uncertainty lingers due to price erosion, slow demand, and volatile raw material costs. The sector faces a challenging second half of 2025.

French Potato Sector Under Strain as Processors Push to Revise Contracts

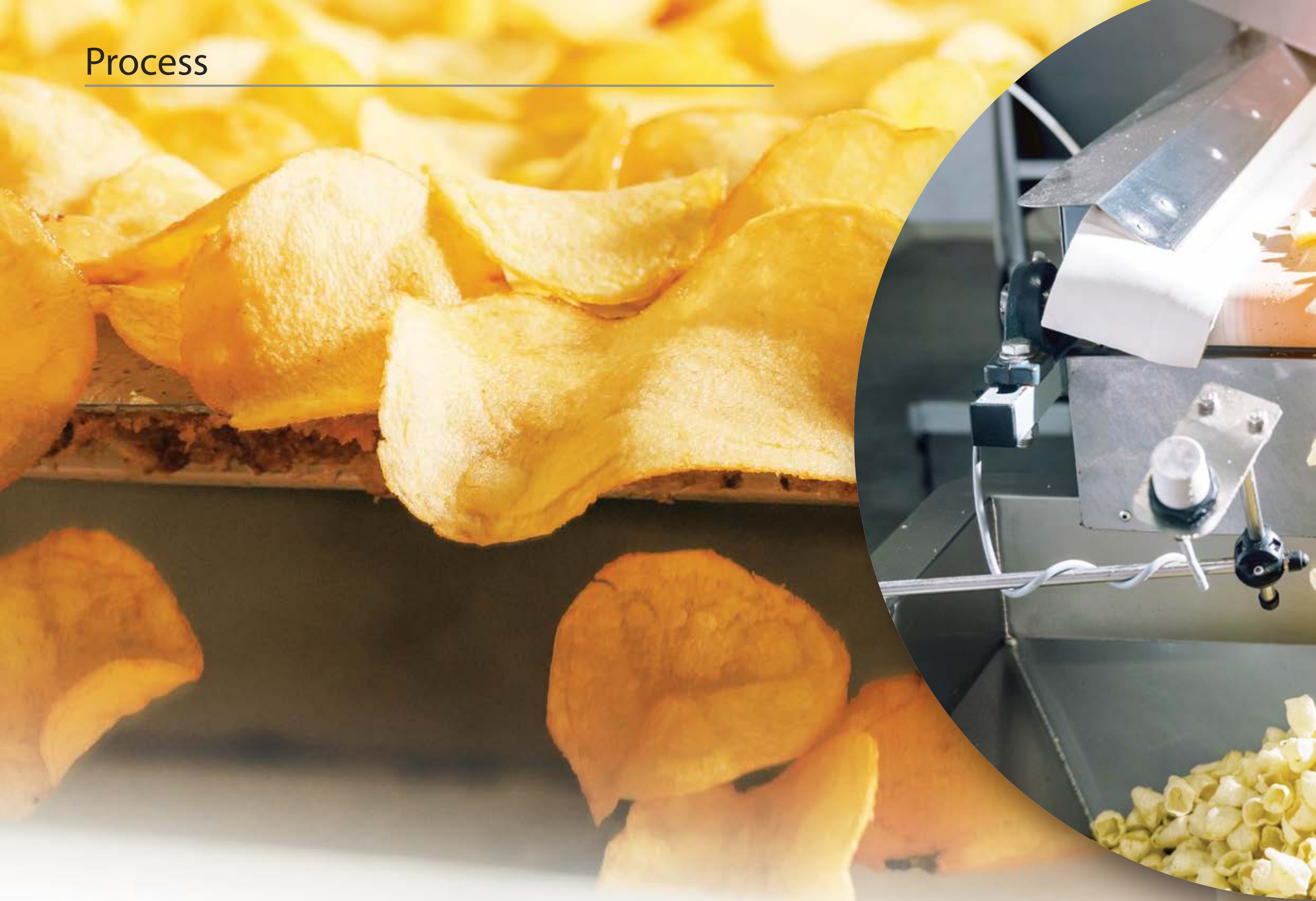
Tensions are rising in the French potato sector as processors reportedly attempt to renegotiate contracts already signed with growers for the 2025 harvest. The move, driven by falling demand for processed potato products and growing market uncertainty, has alarmed producer groups who argue that altering agreed terms undermines income stability and trust. Grower organisations have urged French authorities to enforce fair commercial practices and resist pressure to reopen negotiations. The situation unfolds as French potato acreage is expected to increase this season, further complicating the market landscape. With contracts under scrutiny and demand in flux, the outcome may reshape processor-grower relations in the coming months and influence long-term confidence in contractual frameworks across the French supply chain.

Circana: European Snack Market Hits €234B, Health and Hybrid Trends Shape Future

Europe's snack market reached €234 billion in 2024, growing 2.9% year-on-year, according to Circana. While unit sales held steady at 115 billion, value growth came from snacks with functional health benefits. Potato-based products remain central, but trends toward plant-forward, minimally processed, and clean-label snacks are reshaping consumer expectations. "Brands must treat it less like a category and more like a culture; fluid, hybrid and always evolving," said Ananda Roy, SVP at Circana. Discounters and digital retail posted strong gains, while supermarkets still hold 50% market share. Germany and the UK lead in value, while Italy and the Netherlands top snack share of grocery sales. Circana advises potato processors to go beyond impulse-buy strategies and align with consumer demand for health, sustainability, and new consumption occasions—such as pre-workout or late-night snacking. Reformulation and innovation remain key to staying competitive in the evolving savoury snack segment.

Elea PEF Chip Day 2025 to Showcase Cutting-Edge Potato Chip Processing Technology

Elea will host the PEF Chip Day 2025 on 9 October at its Quakenbrück HQ, immediately following Anuga. The event offers chip producers a close-up look at Pulsed Electric Field (PEF) technology, a non-thermal process that improves product quality and efficiency by reducing cutting force, enhancing texture, and cutting fat uptake. Elea will unveil its new PEF Advantage B Micro system, a compact unit with 1.7 t/h capacity for small to mid-sized producers, alongside its broader high-capacity range. Attendees can join live demos, including a preview of PiCon - an AI-driven acoustic control solution for real-time monitoring. Guest speakers will share PEF production insights, and pre-registered visitors can join one-on-one sessions with Elea experts. The day concludes with a whisky-themed "Chip & Sip" dinner. On 10 October, limited testing slots will allow participants to trial PEF using their own materials. Registration is open at eleapef.com.



Tuned for Tubers: Optimizing Conveyor Tech for Potato Processing Lines

Whether designed for French fry production, flake manufacturing, chip slicing, or IQF packing - the conveyor system is far more than a means of transport. It is a critical part of the hygiene infrastructure, an enabler of product consistency, and a core element in overall line efficiency.

By Tudor Vintiloiu

As automation advances and throughput requirements climb, conveyor systems must now accommodate not just high volumes, but also strict sanitary design, minimal maintenance, and delicate handling where needed. And with space constraints tightening in many plants, footprint and modularity also come into play. Among the most established suppliers for the potato processing industry, **Key Technology** has developed a comprehensive line of vibratory conveyors that are well-suited for raw, wet, and frozen potato product handling. Their Iso-Flo, Impulse, Zephyr, and Marathon models are all designed to manage extremely high throughputs - up to 45,000 kilograms per hour in some configurations - while maintaining consistent flow and alignment. Built in stainless steel and featuring oil-free drives, these conveyors are commonly used to singulate, spread, dewater, or align product streams ahead of downstream operations like optical sorting, cutting, blanching or freezing. Because they use tuned vibratory motion rather than belts or rollers, product damage is minimized and sanitation is simplified. In particular, the lack of enclosed moving parts and the open bed design reduces the risk of bacterial harborage and facilitates fast, effective washdowns. Key's systems are frequently found not just in standalone applications but integrated into full lines, working in concert with sorters and optical graders, and are backed by a five-year warranty - a rarity in

industrial equipment.

Ashworth, another major supplier with deep roots in food processing, brings a different strength to potato facilities. Their spiral and turn-curve belts allow processors to move product vertically or along complex layouts where space is limited. For example, washed and peeled potatoes that must be conveyed to higher levels for further processing often rely on spiral conveyors where linear belts would take up too much floor space. Ashworth's Omni-Grid 360 Weld and PosiDrive Spiral designs feature crevice-free surfaces, smooth welds, and tension-controlled movement - all of which contribute to improved hygiene and reduced cleaning time.

These features are especially relevant in wet environments such as post-peeling or hydro-cutting areas, where stainless steel components must endure daily cleaning with caustics and hot water. Their SmartSpiral remote monitoring platform adds a layer of predictive maintenance, alerting operators to belt fatigue or performance deviations before they result in costly downtime. This level of control, paired with Ashworth's in-house technical service teams and global spare parts availability, makes them a trusted name where hygiene and layout optimization intersect.

One of the newer entrants to gain traction in hygienic conveyor systems is **Dynamic Conveyor**, whose DynaClean S-Series was launched in 2024. Originally developed for broader food processing markets, the S-Series has found increasing relevance in potato processing, especially in wash, peel, and trim areas. Its design philosophy centers on modularity and tool-free disassembly. Conveyor frames are built from HDPE and UHMW plastic rather than stainless steel, which offers high resistance to chemical cleaning agents and eliminates crevices where soil and moisture could accumulate. Sidewalls, chutes, scrapers and belt supports can all be removed without tools, allowing sanitation crews to perform complete disassembly, cleaning, and reassembly in a fraction of the time required for traditional systems. Belt options include solid polyurethane and link-style polypropylene, both FDA-approved and suitable for direct food contact. For potato processors looking to reduce changeover times and sanitation labor hours, DynaClean offers a cost-effective solution that doesn't compromise on performance or compliance.

Complementing these systems are several lesser-known but equally critical technologies that support hygienic performance and process reliability. Fortress Technology, a company better known for its metal detection systems, provides tool-free belt removal systems for conveyor lines that need frequent sanitation. Designed originally for bakery and snack food environments, these mechanisms are increasingly being adopted in potato processing where similar cleaning demands apply. By enabling operators to remove and reinstall belts without tools, these systems reduce the risk of incorrect reassembly and eliminate the possibility of losing fasteners during cleaning - an often overlooked source of foreign body contamination. The ability to restore full belt alignment immediately after sanitation also cuts down on startup waste and idle time.

MINIMIZING CROSS-CONTAMINATION

In facilities where raw product is received in bulk, such as large French fry plants or multi-line chip factories, the conveyor layout must handle dirty, abrasive material at the intake point and transition smoothly to clean environments without cross-contamination. This often means beginning with rugged belt conveyors built with heavy-duty rubber or urethane belts and enclosed structures to contain soil and debris. As the product progresses through washing and peeling, conveyor systems must shift to hygienic stainless steel or modular plastic belts that can withstand aggressive cleaning. Here, companies like Intralox play a crucial role. With more than 40 years of experience in modular belting, Intralox offers solutions such as their ThermoDrive and Series 1700/1750 Flush Grid belts, which are designed to reduce product loss, support belt tracking without tensioners, and offer clean-in-place configurations. Their belts are already used in cutting-edge potato chip plants and are being adopted in IQF lines for their hygienic benefits and system simplicity.

MARKET DEMAND

The trend across all these suppliers is clear: potato processing conveyors must now support food safety and operational uptime with equal weight. Tool-less access, smooth welds, self-tracking belts, and smart sensors are no longer extras - they are essential components of systems expected to operate for thousands of hours annually with minimal unplanned downtime. When selecting or upgrading conveyor equipment, processors are advised to audit not just the product flow but also spatial layout, cleaning protocols, expansion plans, and downstream automation. A well-integrated conveyor doesn't just move potatoes from point A to point B; it feeds the optical sorter at the right rate, it minimizes clumping ahead of the fryer, it ensures accurate orientation before slicing. In some cases, it even acts as a buffer, temporarily holding product while another machine completes a task.

RETROFITTING OPTION

For processors considering upgrades, modular retrofitting is often more feasible than complete line replacements. Adding vibration modules to reduce product buildup, installing new belt types with easier cleaning properties, or implementing sensor-based belt tracking can yield significant improvements at relatively low cost. Systems like Ashworth's belt monitoring or Intralox's clean-in-place adaptations can be integrated into existing structures with minimal engineering, offering a high return on investment while extending equipment life. In contrast, new installations become preferable when layout changes, product mix, or sanitation standards outgrow the capabilities of the existing infrastructure.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Ultimately, as consumer demands evolve and global hygiene regulations tighten, conveyor systems are becoming strategic assets in potato processing. They affect everything from labor cost and energy use to yield and final product quality. The suppliers who continue to push the envelope - whether through smarter control, faster sanitation, or more adaptable materials - are helping shape an industry where every belt, every frame, and every vibration must serve a purpose. In this environment, conveyor systems are no longer invisible links in the process. They are operational platforms, hygiene guardians, and in many cases, the decisive factor between profitability and waste. •